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FOREIGN CONDITIONS

New Zealand has always been a very difficult tour for an Indian cricketer. It's often windy and chilly and that, coupled with the short boundaries in most of the grounds, makes it very different from conditions back home in India. In 1990 the challenge was doubly difficult, with Richard Hadlee, one of the finest ever exponents of swing bowling, close to his best. As a seventeen-year-old on his first tour away from the subcontinent, I was excited about the opportunity.

India in New Zealand, February–March 1990

The first few days in New Zealand were not easy. The accent of the locals there was very strange to our ears and the food took some getting used to. The accent problem resulted in an incident involving Manoj Prabhakar very early in the tour. Prabhakar needed an adapter to charge his gadgets and for some reason decided to put on what he thought was a New Zealand accent while speaking to the housekeeping staff in the hotel. When asking for the adapter on the intercom he was almost chewing up the first 'a', as a result of which the word was sounding like 'dapter' and the staff were having difficulty understanding what he was asking for. Prabhakar got angry after a point and said he needed the 'dapter' immediately. In a few minutes there was a knock on his door and he opened it to find a doctor standing there. The staff had heard 'doctor' for 'dapter' (partly because they pronounced 'doctor' as 'dactor') and had sent the resident physician to Prabhakar's room.